6

Léa

October 1942

The winery was their refuge. It was the only place they were welcome.

On the terrible night Madame Martin expelled them, the sisters decided they would go the next day and explain to the LeBlanc family why André wouldn't be returning.

The morning they arrived at the winery, Virginie stared at the suitcase in Léa's hand. When she asked where they were going, Rose had broken down in tears, saying they had no place to go, and that was when Édouard insisted they stay there with them. In return, the sisters would help with the harvest because André wasn't coming back.

Sweat gathered on Léa's back and legs as she steadied herself, hauling the straps of the basket brimming with grapes over her shoulders. After she tipped the basket full of grape clusters into the wooden crate, Léa returned to the row of vines where Rose was picking the grapes, Paulette by her side.

The little girl followed Rose like a faithful friend, carrying Rose's sketchbook so that she might have a chance to draw when she took a break. Léa was relieved. It seemed they'd made the right decision in coming to Combleux. A fortnight had passed since their arrival, and their old life seemed to belong to another world.

Neither sister missed the boardinghouse's meager dinners, Madame Martin's deceitful behavior, or the constant presence of German soldiers on the street. In Combleux, they worked hard, but there was more food—eggs in the morning for breakfast; fish once a week from the Loire; and on the last Sunday of every month, chicken from the brood that Virginie raised.

The war seemed distant, as if a hidden wall blocked it off from the